

Nabonidus (Babylonian, *Nabu-na'idu*, i. e., "Nabu is glorious") was the son of Nabu-balatsu-iqbi, and must have occupied a distinguished position in the kingdom before he ascended the throne. Like Nebuchadrezzar, he was a great builder, but unlike him by far the greater portion of his labors was given to the reërection of temples. Nebuchadrezzar had constructed palaces, laid out great streets, erected immense walls of defense. It was the glory of Nabonidus to see that gods dwelt more magnificently than men, and that ancient shrines fallen into ruin should arise in a grandeur far exceeding the glory of earlier days. Other kings had been content when rebuilding fallen walls of temples to clear away the rubbish to the ground, leveling off a surface higher than it had been and then building upon it. Nabonidus was not content with work of that character. He must dig down until the earliest foundation stones were discovered. If the temple had been several times rebuilt it interested him to have the records of the several kings who had worked upon it recovered. To this religious, and, if one might so say, archæological, passion we owe much of our knowledge of early Babylonian history, for he had all these records read to him as they were found, and his own inscriptions carefully preserve the accounts of those who had built before him. No longer are building inscriptions dreary wastes of boastful words recording the erection of walls "mountain high," they are now decorated with the names of mighty kings of the distant past, whose honor Nabonidus was proud to record, as he linked his own name with theirs.

To us the archæological researches of the king are not merely interesting; they afford us in some instances our only means of restoring kings of bygone days to